

Occupational Therapy for Arthritis in the UK

Learn how occupational therapy helps arthritis patients in the UK. From joint protection techniques to home adaptations, splints, and energy management.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-19 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Occupational therapists (OTs) are unsung heroes in arthritis management. They specialise in helping you maintain independence in everyday activities despite joint pain and stiffness. In the UK, OT services are available through the NHS and local councils.

What Does an OT Do for Arthritis?

Joint Protection Techniques

OTs teach you how to use your joints in ways that reduce strain and prevent further damage:

- Using larger, stronger joints for tasks (carrying bags on forearms rather than fingers)
- Distributing weight evenly across joints
- Avoiding sustained gripping and pinching
- Planning tasks to avoid prolonged activity and fatigue

Splinting

OTs can make custom splints for:

- Resting splints — worn at night to support joints in a comfortable position
- Working splints — provide support during daily activities
- Thumb splints — for base-of-thumb arthritis, very common
- Wrist splints — stabilise and support inflamed wrist joints

Home Adaptations

OTs assess your home and recommend adaptations:

- Grab rails in the bathroom and by stairs
- Raised toilet seats and shower seats
- Stair lifts or stair rails
- Kitchen aids — jar openers, tap turners, ergonomic utensils
- Lever door handles instead of round knobs

Energy Management (Pacing)

OTs help you balance activity and rest to manage fatigue — one of the most debilitating aspects of inflammatory arthritis.

How to Access OT in the UK



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Through the NHS

- Ask your GP for a referral to NHS occupational therapy
- Many rheumatology departments have OTs as part of their team
- Hospital-based OTs focus on splints and joint protection

Through Your Local Council

- Contact your council's adult social care team for a home assessment
 - Community OTs focus on home adaptations and equipment
 - Some equipment and adaptations are provided free through the Disabled Facilities Grant
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Useful Equipment from OT

- Long-handled shoe horn — avoid bending to put on shoes
- Button hook — fasten buttons with one hand
- Jar opener — reduces hand and wrist strain
- Perching stool — sit while doing kitchen tasks
- Electric can opener, kettle tipper — reduce grip demands

OTs can make a dramatic difference to your daily life with arthritis. Don't hesitate to ask your GP or rheumatology team for a referral.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about occupational therapy for arthritis in the uk?

Short answer: Occupational therapists (OTs) help people with arthritis maintain independence in daily activities. They teach techniques for joint protection, make custom splints, and recommend home adaptations such as grab rails and kitchen aids. OTs also assist with energy management, helping to balance activity and rest. You can access OT services

through your GP, rheumatology department, or local council in the UK.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk